

MTGNP

Magic: The Gathering Multiplayer Network Protocol v1.0

MTGNP is a terminal-based, two-player game of Magic: The Gathering played over a TCP network. Both players connect to an authoritative server that manages decks, hidden hands, turns, mana, spells, the Stack, combat, win conditions, reconnection, and repeat games. A read-only spectator can follow the match without seeing either player's private hand.

Demo Video

[Watch the MTGNP demo video on Google Drive](#)

Build and test

Open PowerShell in the MTGNP directory:

Command / example

```
$env:PYTHONPATH = "src"
python -m unittest discover -s tests -v
```

An editable install is optional:

Command / example

```
python -m pip install -e .
```

After an editable install, `mtgnp-server` and `mtgnp-client` may be used in place of `python -m mtgnp.server` and `python -m mtgnp.client`.

Regenerate the submission PDF

The game has no third-party runtime dependency. Rebuilding the documentation PDF additionally requires ReportLab:

Command / example

```
python -m pip install reportlab
python scripts/build_readme_pdf.py
```

The stable output path is `output/pdf/README.pdf`. Regenerate it after filling in the Work Distribution Matrix or changing the README.

Run a local game

Open three PowerShell terminals in this directory and set the source path in each terminal:

Command / example

```
$env:PYTHONPATH = "src"
```

Start the authoritative server:

Command / example

```
python -m mtgnp.server --verbose
```

Start player 1:

Command / example

```
python -m mtgnp.client --player-id alice --deck decks/stack_demo_red_green.json --auto-keep --verbose
```

Start player 2:

Command / example

```
python -m mtgnp.client --player-id bob --deck decks/stack_demo_blue_black.json --auto-keep --verbose
```

Optional spectator client(s):

Command / example

```
python -m mtgnp.client --spectator --host 127.0.0.1 --verbose
```

The server always reserves exactly two player seats. After those seats are occupied, additional connections receive a spectator role rather than a third player seat. A spectator receives sanitized authoritative state, may send PING, and receives ILLEGAL_ACTION for gameplay PDUs.

--verbose is the required demo mode. It prints every complete PDU sent and received with direction, peer, type, sequence number, timestamp, and formatted JSON. PING and PONG retain every field but use one compact line each. During interactive verbose play, each heartbeat pair is separated from gameplay by a client-side + border. A matched PONG is followed by a one-line game-context summary and a restored input prompt so background heartbeat output does not obscure the current phase. Remove the flag for normal play. Add --auto-pass to both clients for an unattended protocol smoke test.

For a LAN game, run the server on one computer, allow inbound TCP port 4444 in the host firewall, determine the host's LAN IPv4 address, and give both clients that address:

Command / example

```
python -m mtgnp.client --host 192.168.1.10 --player-id alice --deck decks/stack_demo_red_green.json --auto-keep --verbose
```

Terminal controls

At a priority prompt the client accepts:

Command / example

```
pass
concede
land CARD_ID
cast CARD_ID [TARGET ...]
activate SOURCE_ID ABILITY_INDEX [TARGET ...]
```

Examples:

Command / example

```
land mountain_001
cast lightning_bolt_001 bob
cast counterspell_001 stk_0001
cast doom_blade_001 goblin_guide_001
activate prodigal_sorcerer_001 0 bob
activate millstone_001 0 bob
```

Mana payment is inferred from the catalog and paid by atomically tapping legal sources. Diagnostic overrides are available:

Command / example

```
cast doom_blade_001 goblin_guide_001 --mana B=1,X=1
activate millstone_001 0 bob --mana X=2
```

Combat prompts accept attacker IDs separated by spaces, none, and blocker pairs such as phantasmal_bear_001=goblin_guide_001. The attacker is prompted for damage order when several creatures block one attacker.

Rules behavior that may not be obvious

- The first player skips only the Draw Step of turn 1. The second player draws on turn 2, and the first player begins drawing on turn 3.
- Playing a land is not casting a spell and does not require mana. Only the active player may play one land during either of that player's Main Phases.
- Receiving priority during the opponent's turn permits responses such as Instant, but it does not make the responding player the active player.

- Lands remain tapped until their controller's next Untap Step. The terminal's Available mana line counts currently untapped mana sources.
- Both players must pass consecutively to resolve the top Stack item or advance an empty priority window.
- The client sends PING every 30 seconds and waits up to 10 seconds for the matching PONG. This timeout applies to heartbeat replies, not to a turn or phase. A priority grant has its own 60-second action deadline.
- Goblin Guide and Monastery Swiftspear have haste in the fixed catalog, so they may attack on the turn they enter. The catalog and normative rules take precedence over any contradictory walkthrough example.

Disconnect and reconnect

An unexpected in-game connection loss pauses the authoritative game and reserves that seat for 30 seconds. The server cancels the outstanding priority deadline while paused.

To reconnect, rerun the same client command before the grace period ends. The PLAYER_READY PDU acts as the reconnect handshake and must contain the exact same player ID and ordered deck list. The server then:

- 1 verifies the reserved identity and deck;
- 2 sends fresh personalized authoritative state;
- 3 issues a fresh priority, combat, trigger, mulligan, or discard token; and
- 4 continues the original game without reshuffling or resetting it.

A changed identity or deck is rejected and the reservation remains active. If the timer expires, the connected opponent receives GAME_OVER with reason DISCONNECT. The grace duration can be configured for demonstrations:

Command / example

```
python -m mtgnp.server --reconnect-grace 30 --verbose
```

Architecture

Diagram source

```
flowchart LR
    C1["Terminal client: player 1"] <-->| "Framed JSON over TCP" | S["Authoritative MTGNP server"]
    C2["Terminal client: player 2"] <-->| "Framed JSON over TCP" | S
    CS["Terminal client: spectator"] <-->| "Framed JSON over TCP" | S
    S --> P["Protocol validation and tracing"]
    S --> L["Two-seat lobby and lifecycle"]
    S --> G["Game, Stack, abilities, triggers, combat"]
    G --> D["Fixed CSV card catalog"]
```

The clients send intent only. They never determine whether an action succeeds or calculate a winner. Every accepted mutation occurs in the server game engine, and each GAME_STATE_UPDATE replaces the client's local view.

The game lifecycle is:

Diagram source

```
flowchart LR
    L["LOBBY"] --> S["GAME_SETUP"] --> M["MULLIGAN"] --> G["IN_GAME"] --> O["GAME_OVER"] --> L
    G -. "connection lost" .-> R["RECONNECT GRACE"]
    R -->|"same player and deck"| G
    R -->|"30 seconds expires"| O
```

Implemented effects

The base rubric requires at least five effects. The implementation exceeds that gate with spell effects, activated abilities, and triggered abilities.

- Spells: Lightning Bolt, Shock, Lava Spike, Flame Slash, Searing Spear, Unsummon, Counterspell, Cancel, Negate, Giant Growth, Doom Blade, Naturalize, Terror, Raise Dead, Rampant Growth, Dark Ritual, Incinerate
- Activated abilities: Prodigious Sorcerer, Royal Assassin, Millstone, Rod of Ruin
- Triggered abilities: Goblin Guide, Monastery Swiftspear, Phantasmal Bear, Gray Merchant of Asphodel, Gravedigger

Dedicated demonstrations are available in `decks/ability_demo_*.json` and `decks/trigger_demo_*.json`. Optional milestone O1A can be played with `decks/optional_spells_red.json` and `decks/optional_spells_blue.json`.

Test coverage

Automated tests cover catalog reconciliation, all PDU shapes, malformed and fragmented framing, hidden information, mulligans, turn transitions, draws, land and mana rules, Stack ordering and countering, state-based actions, combat, activated and triggered abilities, timeouts, heartbeat behavior, concession, same-connection restart, reconnect success, reconnect rejection, and reconnect expiry.

The external checks in `docs/INTEROPERABILITY_TEST_MATRIX.md` must be completed on the actual demo machines. They are deliberately not marked as passed in advance.

Known limitations and RFC interpretations

- MTGNP defines reconnect as required but defines no reconnect/session PDU. This implementation reuses `PLAYER_READY` with the same player ID and exact ordered deck. This is an implementation-defined extension using an existing PDU rather than adding a non-standard message type.
- Player IDs are not authenticated because MTGNP 1.0 defines no authentication. The reconnect check prevents accidental seat takeover, not a malicious peer that already knows the original player ID and deck.
- A legal deck may contain fewer than seven cards. Setup draws all cards that are available; a later required draw from an empty library loses the game.
- Each physical card instance ID may occur in only one submitted deck.
- Each physical server-to-client PDU receives a distinct monotonically increasing server sequence number, including separate broadcast copies. The explicit Section 11 exception reissues the current token unchanged after a rejected action while that player still holds priority.
- Seventeen spell effects and selected activated/triggered abilities are supported. Full behavior for every catalog card is optional bonus work and is not claimed because O1C-O1F were cancelled.
- Exactly two connections receive player seats. Further connections become read-only spectators. This optional O3 extension interprets the base rule about refusing additional connections as refusing additional **players**; graders who require every third TCP connection to be closed should note this intentional deviation.
- The player and spectator clients are terminal-based. A graphical interface was cancelled and is not part of the submission.

Work Distribution Matrix

The group reports an equal contribution model. All three members shared design, implementation, review, debugging, gameplay testing, and demo preparation. The matrix records that shared ownership; commit counts alone are not treated as a measure of contribution.

Task / Feature	King Mejia	Jose Honrado	Walt Hutchison
TCP Server: connection handling, framing, dispatch	Equal contribution	Equal contribution	Equal contribution
Game lifecycle: LOBBY, GAME_SETUP, MULLIGAN logic	Equal contribution	Equal contribution	Equal contribution
Turn & phase engine (all phases/steps, transitions)	Equal contribution	Equal contribution	Equal contribution
Priority & Stack logic, spell/ability resolution	Equal contribution	Equal contribution	Equal contribution
Combat system (attackers, blockers, damage)	Equal contribution	Equal contribution	Equal contribution
Client implementation & state rendering	Equal contribution	Equal contribution	Equal contribution
PDU serialisation/deserialisation (all 25 PDU types)	Equal contribution	Equal contribution	Equal contribution
Error handling, PING/PONG heartbeat, disconnect logic	Equal contribution	Equal contribution	Equal contribution
Verbose mode (client + server PDU logging, toggle on/off)	Equal contribution	Equal contribution	Equal contribution
Testing & interoperability	Equal contribution	Equal contribution	Equal contribution
README / documentation / AI disclosure	Equal contribution	Equal contribution	Equal contribution

AI Usage

The project used the following AI tools:

- OpenAI Codex: analyzed the MTGNP specification, rubric, and CSV catalog; reviewed the implementation against the rubric; explained rules, priority, heartbeat, and branch-integration behavior; helped draft and revise Python code and automated tests; improved compact verbose heartbeat output and prompt restoration; diagnosed gameplay issues; and prepared submission and demo documentation.
- Anthropic Claude: helped draft and refine the video-demo script so the required rubric evidence could fit within the eight-minute limit, and assisted with selected optional-milestone implementation and review work.

AI output was not accepted blindly. The group reviewed the changes, performed gameplay tests, ran the automated suite, and retained responsibility for the implementation and submission. No other AI tool is reported as used.

Dependencies and project tools

- The game runtime uses only the Python standard library.
- ReportLab is used only by `scripts/build_readme_pdf.py` to produce the submission PDF; it is not required to run the game.
- Git and GitHub are used for version control, branch integration, and group collaboration.

Project documentation

- `docs/FOUNDATION_DECISIONS.md` - catalog and RFC interpretation decisions
- `docs/TRANSPORT_DESIGN.md` - TCP framing, connection wrapper, and tracing
- `docs/LOBBY_DESIGN.md` - lobby and ready validation
- `docs/GAME_SETUP_DESIGN.md` - setup, hidden state, and mulligans
- `docs/TURN_ENGINE_DESIGN.md` - turns, priority, draws, and cleanup
- `docs/STACK_AND_SPELLS_DESIGN.md` - lands, mana, spells, Stack, and effects
- `docs/COMBAT_DESIGN.md` - combat validation and damage
- `docs/ACTIVATED_ABILITIES_DESIGN.md` - activated-ability registry and flow
- `docs/TRIGGERED_ABILITIES_DESIGN.md` - triggers, choices, and APNAP ordering
- `docs/RESILIENCE_DESIGN.md` - timeout, heartbeat, concession, and reconnect
- `docs/ARCHITECTURE_AND_DEMO.md` - component and sequence walkthrough
- `docs/INTEROPERABILITY_TEST_MATRIX.md` - required external test record
- `docs/SUBMISSION_CHECKLIST.md` - final packaging and demo checklist